

drawn, customers segregated according to locale and a pitch is made to draw in the majority. Gaming for the young, e-mails for the old—a generalisation for sure, but reality is not far from this. “We offered only surfing initially, but our customers demanded more games and we took off from there. We offer browsing, printing, scanning, the usual... but concentrate on games—70 to 80 per cent of our customers are gamers. The age group varies between 6-year olds to 40-year olds, the oldest gamer that we have had is 32-years old,” says Yogesh. The concept of a gaming cafe is still new, and is concentrated in the more affluent sections of a town or city where customers can afford to pay for a quick frag. “Gaming cafes are too few. No one knows that games are out there, they can be an attractive proposition. Our customers bunk lectures and come to my cafe. Parents should encourage gaming. Gaming is shunned in India, while gamers abroad get paid to both play and test games,” says Yogesh.

Cyber cafe is people

‘A Family Entertainment Centre’, announces the brochure. It had to happen. A McDonald’s with computers? The intent has been rendered, if not quite in

ambience; certainly in the content of fast food and faster internet access. Dhiraj Gejria is the brains behind FastMindz. A 22-year old, unmarried, commerce graduate from MMK College, he worked for Sun Infoways for 2 years as a Chief Course Consultant. Dhiraj also freelanced as a designer dabbling in the electronic media—Web pages, Flash animations and CD-ROM presentations. With a background in sequestering thoughts, it comes as little surprise to learn of the triumvirate of Classic Mindz, Virtual Mindz and Privilege Mindz. It is a concept best explained by Dhiraj himself.



Bhushan Kadam
Beenstalk
ON SERVICES PROMISED BY RELIANCE

“Basically their technology is not good. *Maaza nahi hain*. You might have Schumacher sponsoring your car but if your car is bad, how will it sell?”

“We wanted to start a Family Entertainment Centre. We wanted parents to bring their kids along, such that the kids can play games, surf the Internet or eat snacks while the parent works. With that in mind, we have designed the place into three sections: A surfing (Classic Mindz) section where ergonomics is firmly in mind with recessed monitors, a gaming

Illegal operation

A cyber café owner pointed out an interesting juggle that some owners perform to soften the bills. A normal dial-up Internet connection has a pulse rate of Rs 1.20 for three minutes, or Rs 24 per hour. A PCO however has the subsidised rate of Rs 0.60 for three minutes, or Rs 12 per hour. Certain cafés, especially those that are close to a PCO booth, tap into the PCO lines and use the same for their Internet connection. It is a 50 per cent reduction in cost, and thoroughly illegal.

section (Virtual Mindz) where the monitors are kept at a height and at a convenient distance to reduce eye-strain. The third section, Privilege Mindz is where you have video-conferencing, voice-chat, Net-2-Phone (voice over IP), etc. We have multi-functional PCs. The most popular games are installed on all machines, while the gaming section has been segregated by a glass partition to minimise noise and distractions for other customers.”

A young age group needs its entertainment for sure, but what of assignments and project reports—the duller aspects of youth? Vishal Kandoi is the man in-charge of Cupid’s Nest. This cafe sits right outside the gates of D Y Patil college in a suburb of Mumbai, and quickly satiates the needs of the studying crowd—food and printouts. “The cyber cafe was secondary. People coming here are college students. The main attraction is the fast food... joints that offer only surfing do not do so well—ice-cream and cold drinks go well with the Internet: Something to munch and surf.” Dependence on a particular segment brings along the trepidations of withdrawal. “I have a slack season when the colleges are not open, otherwise the business is great. It is not that profitable,” he quickly adds—lest the tax man come knocking. Yogesh faces a similar reality: “The response is seasonal. As gamers are a larger percentage of our clientele, examinations see a slack in the number of customers.”

Iqbal Singh of Jeet cyber cafe lives in interesting times. He is surrounded by similar endeavours; most offer better bandwidth and speeds, yet this amiable youth (who refuses to divulge his age) remains unfazed. “Cyber cafes are not running because of speeds and stuff; good speeds are a part of it, but customer

Cyber Warez

“We have legal copies of Windows and of Word for two PCs, the rest house EasyOffice. We lose users because of EasyOffice but it is better than being raided and asked to close shutters.” Like Dhiraj Gejria of FastMindz, most cyber cafés have legal and multiple versions of at least two software: Microsoft Windows OS (generally Windows 98) and Microsoft Word. Anything else is a freeware version (EasyOffice), a non-registered version of a shareware (WinZip) or a pirated copy (Adobe Photoshop). Linux is nowhere to be found. The reasons vary from: “Most people don’t know how to work with Linux. I am not sure if Linux is compatible with browsing,” says Kandoi of Cupid’s Nest, to “Most of the games require patches and drivers to work under Windows XP...

Linux also has compatibility problems with games and software,” as Gejria of FastMindz says.

The reason for piracy is also, predictably, that of prohibitive costs. As one café owner on condition of anonymity confessed, “Original software is not affordable and the returns are not great. You need a separate license for each PC. I have to keep five licenses for each version of Norton Antivirus, each for Rs 2,000. I am not earning that much, why should I then invest? Similarly for Windows, the investment would run into lakhs.” Most owners though take the stance of Bhushan Kadam of Beenstalk: “In India, lots of things about piracy are not very clear. So I try to steer clear of questionable software.”